and even a nail polish that can detect drugged drinks. In August, the state of California began handing out free kits to detect date rape drugs.

Back in India, though the problem has been acknowledged, authorities have been slow to act. In 2013, after a man was sentenced to 10 years in prison for drugging and raping a girl, a Delhi court expressed concern over drug-induced sexual assault and asked for date rape drug testing to be a mandatory part of rape kits. That same year, Ketamine was included in Schedule X of the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, making it harder to obtain. The court also asked the Delhi Commission for Women to lay down norms for sensitising people. These guidelines were submitted to the city police and the government in 2014, and the Commission also circulated the guidelines among 90 mahila panchayats and 11 crisis intervention centres.

Apart from these measures, in 2016, Maneka Gandhi wrote to the Drugs Controller General of India about a case in which a consignment of Ketamine was illegally diverted from Delhi Zoo. In 2017, the Delhi High Court upheld a ruling that illegal and non-medical use of Ketamine warrants strict penal provisions.

THE SOCIAL TABOO

Educationists and counsellors in India, however, say that while laws and drug detection devices may help, the real problem lies elsewhere. Chances of victim-blaming are high when the person does not have any memory of the incident, let alone concrete proof. It also prevents victims from speaking out openly. "In 2018, my friend and I went on a double date to a bar in Bandra, Mumbai. We were only 16 then," says Pune-based student Vrinda Malhotra. "The next morning, she called and said she had woken up in a hotel room with no clothes on. She was alone, there were no injuries, but she could not remember anything from the night before." Having no memory of the incident makes it harder to legally prosecute abusers. "How could we blame her partner when we did not even know what happened? He claimed to be innocent. Three years later, my friend is still undergoing therapy," says Malhotra.

"Date rapes have been around for a while now. But it's still victims who face all the blame. People often say 'if you knew how the person is [the abuser], why did you go out with them?'" says women's rights activist Kavita Krishnan. Social conditioning and integration also play a role. Many colleges now have counsellors to help students. Sunita George, principal of the Bombay Scottish School in Mumbai, says, "Many youngsters consume substances because it is the 'in' thing to do, but without awareness or guidance." P. George, 23, a software engineer from Chennai, recalls how he took to alcohol to combat anxiety around women. "For a long time, I didn't know how to speak to girls. My friends suggested that I try alcohol, but it did not help much. Once, while on a date, a friend suggested I mix four shots of rum in my girlfriend's cocktail while telling her it was just one shot, because then, we would be able to 'have more fun'. I didn't do it, but I know of people who have done this to their partners."

"Young people need reliable and trustworthy guides. Coming to a new city for college, starting a new chapter, can be daunting," says Anju Srivastava, principal of Hindu College in Delhi. Dinesh Singh, chancellor of K.R. Mangalam University, is of the same opinion: "Colleges have a diverse mix of people. It is up to the institute to integrate everyone instead of letting barriers form."

But this integration must start sooner, say educators. "Parents are often in denial—they think their child is still young, doesn't go on dates, and so on. They don't think it is time to have honest conversations around substance or sexual abuse," says George. Then, there's also a lack of understanding. For instance, Nangia says, "My friends and I lie about our social life because our parents always stop us, never help us. They don't understand that dating and drinking is normal today."

Awareness is usually the immediate life-saver when one finds themselves in a 'roofie' situation. As Nangia recalls, it was only because she knew of such drugs that she could sense that something was amiss. Drug detection kits and laws can help, but not if society is unwilling to either acknowledge or understand the problem. Denial—and ignorance—can be as dangerous as the drugs themselves. ■



"CASES OF DATE RAPES HAVE BEEN AROUND FOR A WHILE NOW. BUT IT IS STILL VICTIMS WHO USUALLY FACE ALL THE BLAME"

KAVITA KRISHNAN
Women's rights activist



"GHB, ROOFIES AND KETAMINE ARE COMMON PARTY DRUGS AND ARE CHEAPER THAN COCAINE OR HEROIN"

DR I.R. RAJKUMAR
Medical Director, Alpha Healing Centre, Vadodara